signal or chose to ignore it. Describing the Chinese tests as 'retrograde and deplorable', [5] Shastri rejected the Chinese explanation, saying the Chinese action placed 'serious obstacles' towards the elimination of nuclear weapons. Perhaps a chance was lost, although in retrospect it is not clear whether the Chinese were serious about this idea.

The Chinese expected us to test our own nuclear device sooner or later. In June 1971, Zhou told Romanian President Nicolae Ceausescu that 'as far as the production of the atom bomb is concerned, probably India wants to create an equilibrium in its relations with China'. [6] When India tested its nuclear device in May 1974, the Chinese statement, issued on 19 May 1974, was, therefore, factual. More intriguingly, there were no public references to India's test when Pakistan's Foreign Minister, Agha Shahi, came visiting China from 6 to 10 June 1974. In private, however, the Chinese were dismissive. Japan's Prince Saiyonji reported Vice Premier Deng Xiaoping as telling him that India's nuclear test was not likely to help raise India's prestige in the world. [7] The Chinese were careful not to link India's nuclear test to the Chinese tests. This was a calculated move. They did not wish to give any opportunity for India to be equated with them. Hence, the two commentaries in *People's Daily* on the subject of India's nuclear tests, on 28 June and 3 September 1974, described India as a 'sub-super power' intent on 'nuclear blackmail and nuclear menace in the South Asia region'. There was no reference to the impact of India's test either in the larger Asian context or the global context.

China had, presumably, already begun to help Pakistan with its nuclear programme. In November 1974, when US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger met with Vice Premier Deng Xiaoping in Beijing, he casually dropped a bait by telling Deng that the head of his policy planning staff, Winston Lord (later the American Ambassador to China in the 1980s), had been in